

SQL Injection – UNION Attack: Finding a Column Containing Text

Lab

PortSwigger Web Security Academy

Vulnerability

SQL Injection (UNION-based)

Objective

Identify which column in the query result can contain text by using a **UNION SELECT** attack.

Methodology

1. Selected a product category and tested the **category** parameter for SQL injection.
2. Used **UNION SELECT** to determine the number of columns returned by the original query.
3. Tested different columns with a unique text string.
4. Identified the column that successfully displayed the supplied text.
5. Used the correct column to complete the lab.

Example Payload

```
' UNION SELECT NULL,'test',NULL--
```

The exact number and position of **NULL** values may vary depending on the application's query structure.

Impact

A UNION-based SQL injection can allow an attacker to manipulate database queries and potentially retrieve sensitive database information.

OWASP

OWASP Top 10 – A03:2021 Injection

Result

Successfully identified the column capable of containing text and solved the PortSwigger lab.